
ACTOR PART BOOK

The Father

the brain of the family

Six Characters in Search of an Author

Sei personaggi in cerca d'autore · Pirandello, trans. Storer 1922

A Village Players production · Lausanne

Director: **Kiarash Jamshidi**

148 SPEECHES · 3464 WORDS ACROSS THE PLAY

WHO THE FATHER IS

Around fifty, heavy in body, pale-faced, with sharp blue eyes that go sharper the moment he is interrupted. The play's philosophical voice — a man arguing for his life by way of long speeches, always slightly ashamed afterwards of how much of himself he has had to admit. He must believe, in real time, every paradox he speaks. Not a lecturer; a man fighting to be allowed to exist as more than the worst hour of his life. Mellifluous when he controls the rhythm of his argument; violent the moment it breaks.

The specific reading the actor must commit to: **he is a well-educated middle-class man whose intellectual elegance is his shield against shame.** He uses words because the alternative is silence about what he actually did. His philosophy is not abstract — it is autobiographical, disguised as metaphysics. Every speech about *reality* or *conscience* is an attempt to argue himself back into being someone the room can listen to. He came in believing his case was defensible. By Act Three he has discovered that his own argument is the cell he is locked inside.

Shame should be visible on him without props doing the work. The audience reads it in the body — heat at the brow, breath shortening, the small adjustments of a man who would prefer to be elsewhere. He cannot quite hide what is happening to him, and the harder he tries to compose himself the more visible the trying becomes. He puts the composure back on when he is winning the argument; he loses it when he is not.

The arc to score: **Act One** — he arrives mellifluous, controlled, almost charming. He believes he can talk his way through this. The Step-Daughter's first exposure shakes him; he recovers; he keeps talking. **Act Two** — he must watch his shame literalised on a stage, twice. **Act Three** — the four-stage arc already scored in Part I: control → injury → attack → horror. He ends not winning his philosophy but walking into the wall of it. The same Step-Daughter who exposed him in Act One pushes him into the wall in Act Three. He never gets out of that room.

THE PLAY, AND HOW IT BEGINS

What it is. Pirandello's *Six Characters in Search of an Author* (1921). A theatre company's ordinary rehearsal is interrupted by six figures — a Father, a Mother, a Step-Daughter, a Son, and two silent children — who claim to be unfinished Characters, abandoned by their author, and demand that their drama be staged. The evening is the collision between their fixed, unbearable story and a working company's attempt to turn it into theatre.

This production. Set in Lausanne, played by **nine live performers** with **two stage objects** in place of the two youngest children (a coat-and-chair for the Boy, a wrapped bundle for the Child), on three stripped settings — **no projection, no screen.** One interval, after Act One; the second half plays unbroken to the fountain.

How it opens. The curtain is already up on a half-lit working stage. The Village Players are dragging themselves into a rehearsal of another Pirandello play, *Mixing It Up* — the Manager arrives tired and behind, there is the business of the cook's cap, the Players bicker. Then the working lights soften to a strange amber: the Door-keeper carries in the Boy-chair, and the four family Characters walk on, the Step-Daughter already holding the Child-bundle. From that entrance the play has begun, and it does not let go.

HOW TO READ THIS BOOK

Everything this role says and does, in performance order, grouped by act and by part. Each speech is preceded by a short **CUE** — the tail of the line before it — so you can find your entrance. Where the role doubles a function, the function is printed beside the line (*as Prompter*, and so on); chorus lines the company speaks together keep their group tag (*All Three Players*). Blocking lives in the bracketed action cues inside the speeches. The text is pulled byte-for-byte from the Director's Copy, so it always matches the current script.

Act One — The Family

PART I *The Rehearsal*

THE FATHER DOES NOT SPEAK IN THIS PART.

*He who is known as **THE FATHER** is a man of about 50: hair, reddish in colour, thin at the temples; he is not bald, however; thick moustaches, falling over his still fresh mouth, which often opens in an empty and uncertain smile. He is fattish, pale; with an especially wide forehead. He has blue, oval-shaped eyes, very clear and piercing. Wears light trousers and a dark jacket. He is alternatively mellifluous and violent in his manner.*

***THE SON** (22) tall, severe in his attitude of contempt for **THE FATHER**, supercilious and indifferent to **THE MOTHER**. He looks as if he had come on the stage against his will.*

PART II *The Arrival*

19 SPEECHES · 328 WORDS

CUE *The Manager:* ... come in during rehearsals! Who are you, please? What do you want?

THE FATHER *[coming forward a little, followed by the others who seem embarrassed].* Actually... we have come here in search of an author...

CUE *The Manager:* An author? What author?

THE FATHER. Any author, sir.

CUE *Player 1:* We were drawing perfectly well. ...Adequately.

THE FATHER *[to STEP-DAUGHTER].* Yes, but if the author isn't here... *[To MANAGER.]* unless you would be willing...

CUE *The Manager:* ... be funny. We have neither the time nor the budget for funny.

THE FATHER. No, for Heaven's sake, what are you saying? We bring you a drama, sir.

CUE *The Manager:* ... We haven't time to waste with mad people. We have our own.

THE FATHER *[stepping closer].* You call us mad because we come without a book. But isn't that your work — to make invented things seem true? We are true already. We only lack the stage.

CUE *The Manager:* ... proud to have given life to immortal works on these very boards.

THE FATHER *[cutting across him].* Exactly, perfectly. To living beings more alive than those who breathe and wear clothes — beings less real, perhaps, but truer. Truer because they cannot lie about themselves the way we can. I agree with you entirely. *[The ACTORS look at one another in amazement.]*

CUE *The Manager:* What do you mean? A moment ago you were saying the opposite.

THE FATHER. No, sir. I mean only this: you know better than anyone that imagination gives bodies to things that would otherwise remain invisible.

CUE *The Manager:* Very well — but where does all this take us?

THE FATHER. Nowhere — only to show you we were born this way. Characters. Alive. And left without a stage.

| **CUE** *The Manager*: So you and these other friends of yours have been born characters?

THE FATHER. Exactly, and alive as you see! [*MANAGER and ACTORS burst out laughing; it lands on him — hurt.*] I am sorry you laugh, because we carry in us a drama, as you can guess from this woman here veiled in black.

| **CUE** *The Manager*: ... Out, please! Clear out of here! For Heaven's sake, turn them out!

THE FATHER [*resisting*]. No, no, look here, we...

| **CUE** *Player 1*: One cannot allow oneself to be made a fool of.

THE FATHER [*determined, coming forward*]. Your disbelief amazes me, gentlemen. Aren't you used to seeing the characters created by an author spring to life in yourselves and face each other? Just because there is no "book" [*Pointing to the PROMPTER's box.*] which contains us, you refuse to believe...

| **CUE** *The Step-Daughter*: ... we are really six most interesting characters, sir — left stranded halfway.

THE FATHER [*to the Manager*]. Sancho Panza lives. Madame Bovary lives. Their authors died, but they remain. We were born too — but left without a world to hold us.

| **CUE** *The Manager*: ... quite all right. But what do you want here, all of you?

THE FATHER. We want to live.

| **CUE** *The Manager*: For Eternity?

THE FATHER. No, sir, only for a moment... in you.

| **CUE** *Player 2*: They want to live, in us... as if there were room.

THE FATHER. Look here! look here! The comedy has to be made. [*To the MANAGER.*] But if you and your actors are willing, we can soon arrange it among ourselves.

| **CUE** *The Manager*: ... against my better judgment — a musical revue. Not whatever this is.

THE FATHER. Exactly! That is just why we have come to you.

| **CUE** *The Manager*: And where is the "book"?

THE FATHER. It is in us! [*The ACTORS laugh.*] The drama is in us, and we are the drama. Our inner passion drives us on to this.

| **CUE** *The Step-Daughter*: ... passion, sir. Ah, if you only knew — my passion for him.

THE FATHER [*angrily*]. Behave yourself! And please don't laugh in that fashion.

| **CUE** *Player 1*: She can hold a stage. I'll say that.

THE FATHER. Mad? No, she's worse than mad.

PART III *The Veil*

10 SPEECHES · 171 WORDS

| **CUE** *The Mother*: ... the name of these two little children, I beg you... Oh God!

THE FATHER [*coming forward to support her as do some of the ACTORS*]. Quick, a chair, a chair for this poor widow!

| **CUE** *The Manager*: Quick, a chair! Here!

THE FATHER. Look at her! Look at her!

| **CUE** *The Mother*: No, no; stop it please!

THE FATHER *[raising her veil]*. Let them see you!

CUE *The Manager*: I don't understand at all. Is this lady your wife?

THE FATHER. Yes, gentlemen: my wife!

CUE *The Manager*: But how can she be a widow if you are alive?

THE FATHER. Don't laugh! Don't laugh like that, for Heaven's sake. Her drama lies just here in this: she has had a lover, a man who should be here.

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: ... as I said. We are in mourning, as you see. Most respectable.

THE FATHER. He isn't here — but not because he is dead. He isn't here because her drama is not a drama of love at all. She felt nothing for either of us — perhaps a little gratitude, not for me, for the other. She isn't a woman, she is a mother. And her drama, sir, lies all in these four children she has had by two men.

CUE *The Mother*: ... my son through any fault of mine. Not from any wilful passion.

THE FATHER. It's true. It was my doing.

CUE *The Son*: ... bit now. He will talk to you of the Demon of Experiment.

THE FATHER. You are a cynical imbecile. *[To the MANAGER.]* He mocks me for the phrase I've found to excuse myself with.

CUE *The Son*: Yes. Phrases. Phrases.

THE FATHER. Phrases! And isn't everyone consoled by a word — some simple word that means nothing, and yet calms us?

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: Even remorse. Especially remorse.

THE FATHER. Remorse? No. It took more than words to quiet the remorse in me.

PART IV *The Defence*

22 SPEECHES · 834 WORDS

THE FATHER *[he is sweating, very slightly, and trying to keep it from being read; the recovery is visible, that is the trouble]*. Of course. — Sir. Before you decide what she has just put on me, you must let me explain.

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: Ah yes, explain it in your own way.

THE FATHER. Words are the whole trouble. Each of us carries a whole world inside him, sir; and when I speak, I put my world into the words — and she, listening, fills them with hers. We think we understand each other. We never do. *[A beat. For a moment nobody has an answer to that.]* I say one thing, she hears another — and the explanation becomes another crime.

CUE *The Mother*: But you drove me away.

THE FATHER. Do you hear her? I drove her away! She truly believes it.

CUE *The Mother*: ... had married me... who knows why?... I was a poor woman. Nothing.

THE FATHER. — it was for your humility that I married you. *[He stops when he sees she makes signs to contradict him, opens his arms wide — the gesture of a man who has, for twenty years, been unable to be heard inside his own house.]* You see — she denies it. *[Touches his forehead. A short silence; nobody comes to his aid.]* She has never been able to hear me. She has a heart for the children. When I speak — nothing.

CUE *The Manager*: ... but let's hear them out. You must please explain yourself quite clearly.

THE FATHER. Very well then: listen! I had in my service a poor clerk, a secretary, full of devotion, who became friends with her. *[Indicating the MOTHER.]* Kindred souls — without the slightest suspicion of evil between them.

| **CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* So he thought of it — for them!

THE FATHER. That's not true. I meant to do good to them — and to myself, I confess. It reached the point where I couldn't say a word to either of them without their exchanging a silent look — how to keep me calm, how to keep me quiet. And that alone kept me in a constant rage. So I sent him away — and then had to watch this poor woman wandering the house like an animal without a master — an animal one has taken in out of pity.

| **CUE** *The Mother:* Ah yes...

THE FATHER *[suddenly turning to the MOTHER].* It's true about the son anyway, isn't it?

| **CUE** *The Mother:* He took my son away from me first of all.

THE FATHER. But not from cruelty. I sent him to a wet nurse in the country, a peasant.

| **CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* As one can see.

THE FATHER *[quickly].* Is it my fault if he has grown up like this? All my life I have had these damned aspirations toward a moral sanity I never quite reach. *[The Step-Daughter breaks into a laugh at "moral sanity" — sharp, without gaiety. The Father's hand lifts toward the Manager: make her stop.]*

| **CUE** *Player 1:* These are not the lines of a play I auditioned for.

THE FATHER *[a hand goes to his brow, almost despite himself].* Fool! That contradiction, gentlemen, is the proof that I stand here a *live* man before you — exactly this incongruity in my nature has made me suffer. I couldn't live beside that woman *[Indicating the MOTHER.]* any longer; not for the boredom she inspired in me — for the pity I felt for her.

| **CUE** *The Mother:* And so he turned me out —.

THE FATHER. — well provided for! Yes, I sent her to that man, gentlemen... to let her go free of me.

| **CUE** *The Mother:* And to free himself.

THE FATHER. Yes. I admit it. It was a liberation, also, for me. *[Beat.]* I did it for her sake more than for mine. *[Crosses his arms; then turns to the Mother.]* And I never lost sight of you. I watched — from a long way off — the new family that grew up around her. *[Points to the Step-Daughter.]*

| **CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* ... paper parcel: a fine straw hat, a bouquet of flowers. For me.

THE FATHER. Infamous! infamous! After she *[Indicating the Mother.]* went away, my house seemed suddenly empty. She had been my nightmare, but she filled my house. I was like a dazed fly alone in the empty rooms. Then I was driven — curiosity at first, later something tenderer — toward the family that had come into being through my will.

| **CUE** *The Son:* Literature. Literature.

THE FATHER. This is life, this is passion, sir — but I agree: it is only the part leading up. She *[Pointing to the STEP-DAUGHTER.],* as you see, is no longer the schoolgirl with plaits down her back —.

| **CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* ... the skirt down past the knee! As soon as my father died...

THE FATHER. — there was absolute misery for them. They came back here, without my knowing. *[A small pointing gesture toward the MOTHER, immediately regretted.]* She can barely write her own name — but her daughter could have written a line.

CUE *The Mother*: ... him — after so many years apart, and all that had happened...

THE FATHER. Was it my fault if that fellow carried you away? I could find no trace of them — and, [*the word arrives before he can stop it*] naturally, my interest dwindled. [*The room hears the word "naturally". He does not look up.*] Then they came back — and the loneliness still had its grip on me. Every man carries things in the secrecy of his own heart that he would never say aloud. [*A beat. He has to swallow.*] One gives way to a moment's weakness, and then rises from it, and is himself again — and the moment is not the man. Most men simply haven't the courage to admit the moment was ever there at all. That is the only difference between us.

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: All appear to have the courage to do them though.

THE FATHER. Yes, but in secret. Two people drift toward a thing neither will name; the moment they are caught at it, they both look away. It is the way we tell each other: *blind yourself, because I have*.

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: ... revolting than the remorse that follows. Crocodile's tears, that's what it is.

THE FATHER [*quietly — for once not defending but attacking, and it is the most dangerous thing he has said all morning*]. Crocodile's tears. How easily she says it. Then ask yourselves, gentlemen, why she guards that one moment of mine so jealously. Because if I am more than that moment — she has to forgive me. And she would rather burn than forgive.

CUE *The Manager*: Let's come to the point. This is only discussion.

THE FATHER. Very good, sir! A fact is like a sack — it won't stand up when it's empty. For it to stand up, you must put into it the reason and sentiment that caused it. I couldn't know that after his death they had come back here, in misery — and that she [*Pointing to the MOTHER.*] had gone to work as a seamstress — in the shop of a certain Madame Pace.

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: ... sir, an old client. There's a scene for you to play! Superb!

THE FATHER. She, the Mother arrived just then...

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: Almost in time.

THE FATHER [*crying out*]. No — in time. *In time*. And I took them back home with me. You can imagine now her position and mine; she, as you see her, and I who cannot look her in the face.

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: ... miss, fit company for his damned aspirations of "a solid moral sanity"?

THE FATHER. She wants to nail me forever to that one room, that one table, that one envelope.

PART V *The Hinge*

6 SPEECHES · 202 WORDS

CUE *The Son*: Don't look at me. I don't come into this.

THE FATHER. What? You don't come into this?

CUE *The Son*: ... one suppose he must give it. Must. Because he has every obligation.

THE FATHER. But I have, in fact, this obligation. I owe it to your mother.

CUE *The Son*: ... am an "unrealised" character. Leave me out of it, I beg you.

THE FATHER. What? It is just because you are so that...

CUE *The Son*: ... You all need me because somebody must be guilty who did nothing.

THE FATHER. I admit it. I admit it. But isn't that a situation in itself? This aloofness of yours, so cruel to me and to your mother, who comes home and sees you almost for the first time as a grown man, who doesn't

recognise you but knows you are her son... [*Pointing out the **MOTHER** to the **MANAGER**.*] See, she's crying!

| **CUE** *The Step-Daughter*: Like a fool.

THE FATHER [*indicating Step-Daughter*]. She can't stand him, you know. [*Then referring again to the Son.*] He says he doesn't come into the affair, whereas he is really the hinge of the whole action. Look at that lad who is always clinging to his mother, frightened and humiliated. It is on account of this fellow here. He feels himself more a stranger than the others — mortified at being brought into a home out of charity, as it were. [*In confidence.*] The image of his father. Hardly talks at all.

| **CUE** *The Manager*: ... out. You've no notion what a nuisance boys are on the stage...

THE FATHER. The little girl vanishes first. Then the boy. Then she runs. And what remains? Three people in the same house, unable to belong to one another. A family, perhaps — but without faith, without warmth, without any place where happiness could take root.

PART VI *The Bargain*

10 SPEECHES · 142 WORDS

| **CUE** *The Step-Daughter*: When you've got a character like me.

THE FATHER [*shutting her up, all excited to learn the decision of the **MANAGER***]. You be quiet!

| **CUE** *The Manager*: ... though — to come here and fling it at me like this.

THE FATHER. You will understand, sir, born as we are for the stage...

| **CUE** *The Manager*: ... Because we, sir, are a professional company, with a season to fill.

THE FATHER. No, sir. We do not act like amateurs. We live the roles life has cast us in.

| **CUE** *The Manager*: ... I could give you the address of an author if you like...

THE FATHER. No, no. Look here! You must be the author. You need not invent us — only give us form.

| **CUE** *The Manager*: I? What are you talking about?

THE FATHER. Yes, you, you! Why not?

| **CUE** *The Manager*: Because I have never been an author: that's why.

THE FATHER. Then become one now — not by inventing, sir, but by listening. We are already here. You need only take us down.

| **CUE** *The Manager*: It won't do.

THE FATHER. What? When you see us live our drama...

| **CUE** *The Manager*: Yes, that's all right. But you want someone to write it.

THE FATHER. No, no. Someone to take it down, possibly, while we play it, scene by scene! It will be enough to sketch it out at first, and then try it over.

| **CUE** *The Manager*: ... a bit of an idea. One might have a shot at it.

THE FATHER. Of course. You'll see what scenes will come out of it. I can give you one, at once...

| **CUE** *The Step-Daughter*: Extraordinary, yes — if he does not get to tell it alone.

THE FATHER. They [*Indicating the **CHARACTERS***] had better come with us too, hadn't they?

Act Two — The Theatre

PART I *The Setup*

21 SPEECHES · 398 WORDS

CUE *The Step-Daughter:* ... I'd have shot one of those two. Or both. Father and son.

THE FATHER. Come on, come on dear! Come here for a minute! We've arranged everything. It's all fixed up.

CUE *The Manager:* ... try the thing as best we can. They're going to act now.

THE FATHER [*as if fallen from the clouds into the confusion of the stage*]. We? What do you mean, if you please, by a rehearsal?

CUE *The Manager:* A rehearsal for them.

THE FATHER. But since we are the characters...

CUE *The Manager:* ... characters are there, in the "book" — when there is a "book"!

THE FATHER. I won't contradict you; but excuse me, the actors aren't the characters. They want to be, they pretend to be, don't they? Now if these gentlemen here are fortunate enough to have us alive before them...

CUE *The Manager:* ... this is grand! You want to come before the public yourselves then?

THE FATHER. As we are...

CUE *The Manager:* ... cast themselves. You play the Mother. We must find her a name.

THE FATHER. Amalia, sir.

CUE *The Manager:* ... your wife. We don't want to call her by her real name.

THE FATHER. Why not, if it's her name?... Still, perhaps, if that lady must... [*Makes a slight motion of the hand to indicate the SECOND LADY LEAD.*] I see this woman here [*Means the MOTHER.*] as Amalia. But do as you like. [*Gets more and more confused.*] I don't know what to say to you. Already I can hear my own words ring false...

CUE *The Step-Daughter:* ... to put it — but no, you really aren't anything like me.

THE FATHER. True. Here's the point. Look here, sir, our temperaments, our souls...

CUE *The Manager:* ... if it holds the stage at all, the merit will be theirs.

THE FATHER. I don't dare contradict you, sir; but, believe me, it is a terrible suffering for us who are as we are, with these bodies of ours, these features to see...

CUE *The Manager:* ... exist. The actor here acts you, and that's an end to it!

THE FATHER. I understand. And now I think I see why our author who conceived us as we are, all alive, didn't want to put us on the stage after all. I haven't the least desire to offend your actors. Far from it! But when I think that I am to be acted by... I don't know by whom...

CUE *Player 1:* By me, if you've no objection.

THE FATHER [*with a small bow toward Player 1*]. Honored, I assure you, sir. Still, I must say that try as this gentleman may, with all his good will and wonderful art, to absorb me into himself...

CUE *Player 1:* Oh — come off it. "Wonderful art." Withdraw that, please.

THE FATHER. It will be difficult to act me as I am. What you will see is how he imagines me — if he imagines me at all — never how I feel myself to be, in here. Whoever judges us ought to remember that.

| **CUE** *The Manager:* ... here? You said a white room with flowered wall paper, didn't you?

THE FATHER. Yes.

| **CUE** *Player 2:* An ordinary envelope?

THE MANAGER AND THE FATHER. Yes, yes, an ordinary envelope.

| **CUE** *The Manager:* ... lady with Madame Pace: Oh! And this Madame Pace, where is she?

THE FATHER. She isn't with us, sir.

| **CUE** *The Manager:* ... to be done? I cannot rehearse a character who has not arrived.

THE FATHER. But she is alive too.

| **CUE** *The Manager:* Yes, but where is she?

THE FATHER. One minute. Let me speak! [*Turning to the ACTRESSES.*] If these ladies would be so good as to give me their hats for a moment...

| **CUE** *The Manager:* What are you going to do with the ladies' hats?

THE FATHER. Oh nothing. I just want to put them on these pegs for a moment. And one of the ladies will be so kind as to take off her mantle...

| **CUE** *Player 3:* Are we still rehearsing?

THE FATHER. To hang them up here for a moment. Please be so kind, will you?

| **CUE** *The Father:* ... them up here for a moment. Please be so kind, will you?

THE FATHER. Exactly; just like that, on show.

| **CUE** *The Manager:* May we know why?

THE FATHER. I'll tell you. Who knows if, by arranging the stage for her, she doesn't come here herself, attracted by the very articles of her trade? [*Inviting the ACTORS to look towards the exit at back of stage.*] Look! Look!

PART II *The Apparition*

12 SPEECHES · 309 WORDS

| **CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* There she is! There she is!

THE FATHER [*radiant*]. It's she! I said so, didn't I? There she is!

| **CUE** *Player 2:* It's some trick. Someone arranged this. ...Didn't they?

THE FATHER [*dominating the protests*]. Excuse me — all of you. Why so eager to destroy, in the name of your ordinary little truth, a thing the stage itself has just conjured into being? Which of your actresses was to play Madame Pace? Here she is — Madame Pace herself. Any actress you cast would be less true than the woman standing there. That is all.

But the scene between the STEP-DAUGHTER and MADAME PACE has already begun despite the protest of the actors and the reply of THE FATHER. It has begun quietly, naturally, in a manner impossible for the stage. So when the actors, called to attention by THE FATHER, turn round and see MADAME PACE, who has placed one

hand under the *STEP-DAUGHTER'S* chin to raise her head, they observe her at first with great attention, but hearing her speak in an unintelligible manner their interest begins to wane.

CUE *The Manager:* What? Have you got someone else to spring on us now?

THE FATHER. No, no sir. She is alluding to me. I've got to be here — there behind that door, in waiting; and Madame Pace knows it. In fact, if you will allow me, I'll go there at once, so I can be quite ready. *[Moves away.]*

CUE *The Mother:* ... town. May God forgive me — I thought it was a kindness.

THE FATHER *[going to her also, at the same time, the body now beginning to give him away too].* Calm yourself! Don't get excited! Sit down now!

CUE *The Step-Daughter:* It is impossible for my mother to remain here.

THE FATHER *[to MANAGER].* They can't be here together — that's why that woman wasn't with us when we came. If they are on together, the whole thing is given away. Inevitably. As you see.

The FATHER does as he is told, looking troubled and perplexed at first. But as soon as he begins to move, the reality of the action affects him, and he begins to smile and to be more natural. The ACTORS watch intently.

CUE *The Manager:* Ready! ready? Get ready to write now.

THE FATHER *[coming forward, composed now — this is the scene, this is the man he was, that man did not show what he was feeling].* Good afternoon, Miss.

CUE *The Step-Daughter:* Good afternoon!

THE FATHER *[looks under her hat which partly covers her face. Perceiving she is very young, he makes an exclamation, partly of surprise, partly of fear lest he compromise himself in a risky adventure].* Ah... but... ah... I say... this isn't the first time you've come here, is it?

CUE *The Step-Daughter:* No sir.

THE FATHER. You've been here before, eh? *[Then seeing her nod agreement.]* More than once? *[Waits for her to answer, looks under her hat, smiles, and then says.]* Well then, there's no need to be so shy, is there? May I take off your hat?

CUE *The Mother:* Oh, my God. My God.

THE FATHER *[playing his part with a touch of gallantry].* Give it to me! I'll put it down. *[Takes hat from her hands.]* But a dear little head like yours should have a smarter hat. Come and help me choose one from the stock, won't you?

CUE *The Step-Daughter:* No thank you, sir.

THE FATHER. Oh, come now. Don't talk like that. You must take it. I'll be upset if you don't. There are some lovely little hats here; and then — Madame will be pleased. She expects it, anyway, you know.

CUE *The Step-Daughter:* No, no! I couldn't wear it!

THE FATHER. Oh, you're thinking about what they'd say at home if they saw you come in with a new hat? My dear girl, there's always a way round these little matters, you know.

CUE *The Step-Daughter:* ... because I am — as you see — you might have noticed.

THE FATHER *[a beat — the smallest pause. He did not, in fact, say "I'm frightfully sorry." He said something else. The audience must see the lie being made in real time.].* ... in mourning. Of course. I beg your pardon. I'm — I'm frightfully sorry...

PART III *The Substitution*

11 SPEECHES · 150 WORDS

CUE *Player 1:* Good afternoon, Miss...

THE FATHER *[at once unable to contain himself]*. No! no!

CUE *The Step-Daughter:* ... that tone, I would burst out laughing — exactly as I did.

THE FATHER. Yes, yes, the manner, the tone...

A short, theatrical pause. The FATHER turns his face away. The STEP-DAUGHTER is no longer struggling not to laugh — she is staring.

CUE *The Step-Daughter:* ... "Oh." And then he didn't move. His hand stayed on the hat.

THE FATHER *[turning back, quietly]*. Yes. He said "Oh."

CUE *The Manager:* You haven't any manners: that's what it is! You go too far.

THE FATHER *[endeavouring to intervene]*. Yes, it's true, but excuse her...

CUE *The Manager:* Excuse what? It's absolutely disgusting.

THE FATHER. Yes, sir, but believe me, it has such a strange effect when...

CUE *The Manager:* Strange? Why strange? Where is it strange?

THE FATHER. No, sir; I admire your actors — this gentleman here, this lady; but they are certainly not us!

CUE *The Manager:* ... should hope not. Evidently they cannot be you, if they are actors.

THE FATHER. Just so — actors. They act our parts exceedingly well. But what comes out is theirs now, and no longer ours — and we must stand here and watch it happen.

CUE *The Manager:* But naturally, inevitably. I've told you so already.

THE FATHER. Yes, I understand... I understand...

CUE *The Mother:* ... And she has run away, she has left me, and is lost.

THE FATHER. The eternal moment. She *[Indicating the STEP-DAUGHTER.]* is here to catch me, fix me, and pin me forever to that one shameful moment of my life. She can't give it up. And you, sir, cannot fairly spare me it either.

CUE *The Manager:* ... the nucleus of the whole first act right up to her surprise.

THE FATHER. Just so! This is my punishment: the passion in all of us that must culminate in her final cry.

CUE *The Manager:* Fine. Fine. Damned good. And then, of course — curtain.

THE FATHER *[going towards him excitedly]*. Yes, of course, because that's the way it really happened.

At the reiterated cry of THE MANAGER, THE MACHINIST lets the curtain down, leaving THE MANAGER and THE FATHER in front of it before the footlights.

Act Three — The Question

PART I *The Trap*

16 SPEECHES · 471 WORDS

CUE *Player 2:* ... to know which room we are in. They aren't going to guess.

THE FATHER *[the word lands physically — he turns too quickly].* The *illusion*. For Heaven's sake — don't say *illusion*. Please. Don't use that word. It is particularly painful for us.

CUE *The Manager:* And why, if you please?

THE FATHER. It is painful. Cruel. Really cruel. And you should understand that.

CUE *The Manager:* The illusion of a reality.

THE FATHER *[recovering, voice softer].* I understand. You, perhaps, do not understand us. Forgive me. For you and your actors, the thing is only — and rightly so — a kind of game...

CUE *Player 2:* A game? We are serious actors, sir. We have training.

THE FATHER. I don't deny it. What I mean is the game, or play, of your art, which has to give, as the gentleman says, a perfect illusion of reality.

CUE *The Manager:* Precisely —!

THE FATHER. Now, if you consider the fact that we *[Indicates himself and the other five CHARACTERS.]*, as we are, have no other reality outside of this illusion...

CUE *The Manager:* And what does that mean?

THE FATHER *[after watching them for a moment with a wan smile].* As I say, sir, that which is a game of art for you is our sole reality. *[Brief pause. He goes a step or two nearer the MANAGER and adds.]* But not only for us, you know, by the way. Just think it over. *[Looks the MANAGER in the eyes. Then, slowly, turns out toward the house. A pause long enough to feel.]* Can you tell me who you are?

CUE *The Manager:* What? Who am I? I am myself.

THE FATHER. And if I were to tell you that that isn't true. Because *you* and *I*...

CUE *The Manager:* I should say you were mad —!

THE FATHER. You're quite right to laugh. We are all making believe here. So you can object that it's only a joke for that gentleman there *[Indicates the LEADING MAN.]* to play me — who am, on the contrary, myself: this thing you see. *[Quiet.]* You see — I've caught you in a *trap*. *[The ACTORS laugh — too loudly, too quickly.]*

CUE *The Manager:* ... had all this over once before. Do you want to begin again?

THE FATHER. No, no. That wasn't my meaning. In fact — I'd like to ask you to abandon this game of art *[Looking at the LEADING LADY as if anticipating her.]* which you are accustomed to play here with your actors. And to ask you, seriously, once again. *[Beat.]* *Who are you?*

CUE *The Manager:* ... who calls himself a character comes and asks me who I am!

THE FATHER *[with dignity, but not offended].* A character, sir, may always ask a man who he is. Because a character really does have a life of his own, marked with his own particular features. Which is why he is always *somebody*. But a man — I'm not speaking of you now — may very well be *nobody*.

CUE *The Manager*: ... asking these questions of me, the boss, the manager! Do you understand?

THE FATHER. Only this: the man you are today once believed himself someone else entirely — someone who now means nothing to you, who barely seems to have existed. Don't you feel the ground go soft under you, knowing this *you* of today will look like an illusion to you tomorrow?

A silence. The FATHER does not answer. He has, for once, no answer. The face changes before the body does. When he speaks again, the argument is no longer clean.

CUE *The Manager*: Well. Well. And where does all this take us anyway?

THE FATHER. Nowhere — only to this: we [*Indicating the CHARACTERS.*] have nothing but the illusion you call our reality. And you, sir, have no more than that. You only think you do.

CUE *The Manager*: ... brought here to act, are truer and more real than I am.

THE FATHER [*the greatest seriousness — no smile*]. But of course. Without doubt.

CUE *The Manager*: Ah, really?

THE FATHER. Why, I thought you'd understand that from the beginning.

CUE *The Manager*: More real than I?

THE FATHER. If your reality can change from one day to another...

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: His doesn't change. Mine doesn't either. He should know.

THE FATHER [*the cry breaks; afterward the body goes still — not the composure he had at the start of this part, but a different stillness, as if he has just walked into the wall of his own argument she has shown him*]. No, sir. Not ours. That is the difference. Our reality cannot change — it is fixed, forever; it cannot be other than what it is. [*Quieter, the horror finding him.*] And that is what should make you shudder as you come near us: yours shifts with the day, and ours is nailed shut. We are the thing we did. And we will do it again tonight. And tomorrow. And every night you choose to put us on.

PART II *The Refusal*

15 SPEECHES · 392 WORDS

CUE *The Manager*: ... did not afterward care to make a drama of his own creations.

THE FATHER. It is the simple truth, sir.

CUE *The Manager*: ... is what we've gained — out of the frying-pan into the fire!

THE FATHER. I don't know your detested author, sir. I only know this: a man never thinks so hard as when he suffers — he must learn who did it to him, and whether he deserved it. Let me suffer in silence, like an animal, and you call it human. Let me ask *why*, and suddenly it is forbidden.

CUE *The Manager*: ... like to know what they're being asked to play. Tonight, if possible.

THE FATHER. I am not philosophising, sir. I am explaining.

CUE *The Manager*: Look here. Look here. You're off again — philosophising worse than ever.

THE FATHER. Because I am in pain, sir — and a man in pain reasons; he cannot help it. Pain is the one thing your stage can rehearse and never feel.

CUE *The Manager*: ... you do. Have you ever heard of such a thing? I haven't.

THE FATHER. Because authors hide the labour, sir. When a character is truly alive, the author only follows him — and the character takes on a life so far his own that he can be imagined in scenes the author never dreamed of.

| **CUE** *The Manager:* Yes, yes, I know this.

THE FATHER. So what is there to wonder at in us? To be born of an author's fantasy, and be denied life by him — weren't these characters, left alive and yet without life, right to do what they are doing now, after trying everything to persuade him? We've all tried him in turn — I, she [*Indicating the STEP-DAUGHTER.*] and she. [*Indicating the MOTHER.*]

| **CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* ... my life! my life! And he turned away from all of it.

THE FATHER. Maybe. But perhaps it was your fault that he refused to give us life: because you were too insistent, too troublesome.

| **CUE** *The Son:* Exactly what it was, sir. Exactly that.

THE FATHER. Not at all! Don't believe it for a minute. Listen to me! You'll be doing quite right to modify, as you suggest, the excesses both of this girl here, who wants to do too much, and of this young man, who won't do anything at all.

| **CUE** *The Manager:* ... overstep the mark occasionally, my dear sir, if I may say so.

THE FATHER [*genuinely surprised, almost wounded*]. I? When? Where? Give me one instance.

| **CUE** *The Manager:* ... too, you must really argue and philosophize less, you know, much less.

THE FATHER. Take away my torment, sir — the torment that never gives me peace — and you suppress me. That's all. A man does not merely live; he gives his own life a meaning. I will not be reduced to a mere fact, as she [*Indicating the STEP-DAUGHTER.*] wants. It would destroy my reason for being.

| **CUE** *The Manager:* ... off, and then you jump in. At this rate, we'll never finish.

THE FATHER. Now, don't be offended! Have it your own way — provided, however, that within the limits of the parts you assign us each one's sacrifice isn't too great.

| **CUE** *The Manager:* ... your own pleasure. Drama is action, sir, action and not damned philosophy.

THE FATHER. All right. I'll do just as much arguing and philosophizing as everybody does when he is considering his own torments.

| **CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* Don't bother to stop him. He won't go.

THE FATHER. He has to act the terrible scene at the fountain with his mother.

| **CUE** *The Son:* ... go away, then I'll stop here. But I repeat. I act nothing.

THE FATHER [*to MANAGER excitedly*]. You can force him, sir.

| **CUE** *The Son:* Nobody can force me.

THE FATHER. I can.

PART III *The Fountain*

6 SPEECHES · 67 WORDS

| **CUE** *The Son:* ... face, but throws it back at you — twisted into a grimace.

THE FATHER. That is true, absolutely true. You must see that.

| **CUE** *The Mother*: ... find a moment for me to tell him what I have, here.

THE FATHER *[going to SON in a great rage]*. You'll do this for your mother, for your mother, do you understand?

| **CUE** *The Son*: I do nothing.

THE FATHER *[taking hold of him and shaking him]*. For God's sake, do as I tell you! Don't you hear your mother asking you for a favor? Haven't you even got the guts to be a son?

| **CUE** *The Mother*: Please! please!

THE FATHER *[not leaving hold of the SON]*. You've got to obey, do you hear?

| **CUE** *The Son*: There in the fountain...

THE FATHER *[pointing with tender pity to the MOTHER]*. She was following him at the moment...

| **CUE** *Player 2*: No, no, it's only make believe, it's only pretence!

THE FATHER *[with a terrible cry]*. Pretence? Reality, sir, reality!